Serve this velvety smooth soup hot, topped with shavings of Parmesan cheese, or chilled with an extra swirl of cream or crème fraîche.

watercress soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 10 MINS **COOK** 15 MINS **FREEZE** 3 MONTHS

HOT OR COLD

2 tbsp butter
1 onion, finely chopped
6oz (175g) watercress
3 ripe pears, cored and coarsely chopped
1 quart (1 liter) vegetable stock
salt and freshly ground black pepper
¾ cup heavy cream
juice of ½ lemon
Parmesan cheese, shaved, to serve
olive oil, to drizzle

1 Melt the butter in a saucepan and cook the onion for 10 minutes, or until soft, stirring occasionally to prevent burning. Meanwhile, trim the watercress and pick off the leaves. Add the watercress stalks to the onion with the pears and stock, and season with salt and pepper.

2 Bring to a boil, cover, and simmer gently for 15 minutes. Remove from the heat and pour into a blender along with the watercress leaves. Process until the soup has a very smooth texture.

3 Stir in the cream and lemon juice, adjust the seasoning, and serve sprinkled with Parmesan shavings and drizzled with a little oil. The soup can be made up to 4 hours in advance and refrigerated until ready to use. To serve chilled, pour the soup into chilled bowls, top with crushed ice, and drizzle with a little olive oil.



CHOOSING WATERCRESS
Locally produced watercress with fresh, round leaves and thick stalks are best. Unwashed leaves will keep in the fridge for several days, but ready-washed ones must be eaten quickly.